

The Lonely LEFT

The CPI(M)'s shadow no longer looms large over the state, with people rejecting its ideology and seeking change. Being non-Leftist is big fashion today.



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**BHATTACHARYA
ADDRESSING A
RALLY IN KOLKATA**

By Abhijit Dasgupta

The early 1990s saw a marked change in West Bengal, which not too many would have noticed. Before that, Bengalis were born almost inevitably with two firm convictions: that Rabindra Sangeet had to be sung at all congregations—cultural or otherwise, with all earnestness—and that being Left was the right thing to do. A man called Suman Chatterjee changed part of that. He became an overnight legend in the Bengali music scene, trashing the harmonium, Rabindra Sangeet and the mellow Hemant Kumar,

and launched into steamy stage pyrotechnics with what he called Jiban Mukhi (Songs for Life). Despite all his revolutionary utterances, Chatterjee—now a Trinamool MP and a Muslim who calls himself Kabir Suman—could not shed one piece of baggage. He remained a leftist pouring vitriol at perceived reactionary demons at the slightest opportunity. Soon, Jiban Mukhi was the thing to be. The Bengali

was now both Jiban Mukhi and leftist and it was all right to be both.

Chatterjee, however, was soon to learn that being leftist served no purpose. He fought the last Lok Sabha elections singing songs for Mamata Banerjee and was elected. His Jiban Mukhi songs, like all lessons in history texts, have also run their course giving way to just-teens in jeans and long unruly tresses with guitars and Bangla

Rock, a genre which has partially eclipsed Rabindra Sangeet from the face of Bengal. This would have been sacrilege even a decade ago, but the Bengali now knows that he has to change. Saying that Tagore is slightly passé is no longer a crime now even in Santiniketan.

Being non-Left is big fashion today, verging almost on commitment. The intellectual has moved convincingly